

SCENE 1: INTRODUCTION

FADE IN

EXT. WHITE PICKET FENCE LAWN - DAY

Open with credit scenes and fun animations with Rye's rough hands as he mows different lawns of Huntington Beach neighborhoods.

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

Juxtaposed to back and forth scenes of what seems like a dainty hand being painted. Swanky, upbeat, salon music.

CREDITS END

EXT. EVENT VENUE - DAY

RYE [18, Vietnamese] narrates from behind a podium while wearing a graduation cap.

RYE (O.S.)
For those of you here who don't
know,

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

A small eye opens on the other side of a tacky rectangular fish tank of a nail salon. We're looking through as the eye follows the fish back and forth.

RYE (V.O.)
Vietnamese is a monosyllabic
language.

The young Rye suddenly digs his hand in the tank to snatch a fish before commotion ensues to stop him.

EXT. VIETNAMESE SCHOOL - DAY

Scene cuts to him at a foldout table desk sitting beside other Vietnamese kids, slightly older.

RYE (V.O.)
There are 6 distinct tones: ṣc,
huỵn, n̄ng, h̄i, ngā, and ngang.

Animation as he explains each of them, like cartoons with onomatopoeias popping out for each.

Rye is attempting to focus but looks lost.

RYE (V.O.)
It is very direct and
straightforward-but one cannot
relegate them to mere sounds,
they're feelings carried through
the mouth.

He raises his hand.

RYE (V.O.)
Hñi means to ask, so, yes, the tone
you use like a question.

His classmates turn around dramatically and stare at him like he's braindead.

EXT. BASKETBALL COURT - DAY

Montage of Rye playing basketball outside with his friends, slightly older again. He goes for a jumpshot. His aim is terrible, but he's a big boy and can do some damage by plowing through everyone else and snatching the ball.

RYE (V.O.)
Nñng means heavy, so you pronounce
the word like you've been grasping
a heavy boulder and that syllable
is the moment you can relieve
yourself of carrying it.

He makes a layup while other smaller kids are simply afraid of getting close to him. He thinks he's good at the game.

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

The eye is older and Rye stands behind the tank, now 18 years old, still tracking the fish back and forth.

CAMERA FOLLOWS HIM UP AS HE STANDS COMPLETELY UPRIGHT AND WALKS TO THE RIGHT, HANDHELD PAN TO HIM WALKING OVER TO SIT ON A STOOL BESIDE HIS MOM AS SHE WORKS ON THE ORIGINAL SET OF NAILS WE SAW IN THE INTRO.

RYE (O.S.)
It's the language my mom and I
speak.

SCENE 2: LIFE WITH NANCY AND RYE

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

NANCY [Early 30s, glamorous] is working on nails of CLIENT [White, Valley Girl Accent] and chattering with an accent that tells you she's Vietnamese before she does.

NANCY

Honey, you want the gel nail or the acrylic?

Rye rolls his eyes from his stool.

NANCY KICKS HIS FOOT UNDER THE DESK.

Rye continues scrolling on his phone until she's done.

NANCY (CONT'D)

Okay, honey, you done. You want the Apple Pay again or you have cash for auntie this time?

Rye is now doing some homework but watching their whole interaction.

CLIENT (CHEWING GUM)

Apple Pay. Thank youu~

Client leaves and Nancy sits back down.

RYE

Ma oi, why do you always have to do that dumb accent thing?

NANCY (WITH REAL VOICE)

Why you always in my business?

RYE

It's weird, ma.

NANCY

I get more tips that way.

RYE

You only do it on white people...

NANCY (IN FAKE ACCENT)

They like it, honey.

Rye rolls his eyes again.

NANCY (CONT'D)
Stop doing that, boy. It's disrespectful.

RYE
Da. I'm going to work now.

NANCY
Ok. You finish your homework? Who today?

RYE
Rich Old Lady down the street again.

NANCY
Homework?

RYE
Yeah, mostly.

NANCY
Imma smack you up if you lie to me again.

RYE
Ok, mom. Should I come back after or will you be home?

NANCY
I'll be here. Make sure to give her a hug. Maybe she'll tip you more.

RYE
That's messed up, Ma. Bye. Love you.

SCENE 3: LANDSCAPING

EXT. WHITE PICKET FENCE LAWN - EVENING

Rye wears headphones. He's enjoying himself as he clips the shrubbery and mows the lawn while the sun sets.

Rye rings CIERRA'S [Old, petite, hard of hearing] doorbell.

RYE
Hi, Ms. Cierra. I'm done with your yard.

CIERRA
Thank you, sweetheart.

Cierra gives him a hug then looks around in admiration.

CIERRA (CONT'D)
It's perfect, as always.

Cierra hugs him. She takes out her wallet and shakily hands him two hundreds.

RYE
Oh, I can't take this.

CIERRA
Where else will my money go, dear?
I'm old. I can't hear much. A
pretty sight in my yard means twice
as much as a pretty song.

Rye reluctantly takes the bill.

RYE
Thank you, Ms. Cierra.

CIERRA
Yes. Come back sooner than later.

SCENE 4: DANIEL ENTERS

The salon bell rings as Rye enters. Sitting in the stool beside Nancy is DANIEL [Late 30s, American, glasses]. Rye daps him up and side hugs Nancy.

DANIEL
Hey, Rye Guy. How was work?

RYE
Not too bad. Two yards today.

NANCY
Only two yards? How you get paid
then?

DANIEL
That means two hundred, Nan. He did
well today.

NANCY
Why you still call me that? You
make me sound like someone's
grandma.

RYE
Alright, Nan. Let's go home.

NANCY
That's Ma to you, boy.

DANIEL
Play nice, you two. Family.

NANCY
Tell him to treat his mother with
some respect.

RYE
Tell her to take a joke if she's
always making them!

DANIEL
That's enough.

Daniel takes out his keys and Nancy locks up shop behind him.

SCENE 5: HOME LIFE

EXT. SHITTY APARTMENT - NIGHT

Unsafe area. Nancy and Rye have a streamlined, seamless routine to enter as quickly as possible. Elevator is broken so they sprint up the stairs. Nancy lags behind and begins coughing at the top.

RYE
Ma, can you go any slower?

NANCY
Can you be any more annoying?

They enter their rundown apartment with a broken lock. A nightstand with two jars. One has a taped note that says "College" and one says "House."

RYE DROPS HIS TWO HUNDREDS INTO HOUSE JAR. NANCY FOLLOWS BEHIND AND MOVES BOTH BILLS INTO COLLEGE.

Rye goes to the fridge and the lights are off.

RYE
Ma, electricity is out again.

Nancy is already sprawled on the couch with a face mask on.

NANCY
You know what to do.

Rye groans and walks over to the generator and smacks it until the lights turn back on.

RYE

Did you look at any houses with Daniel?

NANCY

I'll get to it after next week.

RYE

Ma, please. You keep saying that. I can't live here anymore.

NANCY

Okay, did you do any college applications?

RYE

Yes.

NANCY

Liar. You are a liar. To your own mother.

RYE

I did.

NANCY

To where?

RYE

Cascadia.

NANCY

Community? Are you serious? We did not leave by boat for you to go to community.

RYE

It's just in case. I'm not going anywhere good.

NANCY

Are you even trying?

RYE

Yes. I am. I am always trying.

NANCY

Then why do I have to keep asking you this?

RYE

Then stop nagging me!

NANCY

Then you're going to end up like
me. Young and pregnant and no
money. Ever. And it won't be my
fault.

Rye storms to his room and moves two bills from College to
House. Nancy is still on the couch relaxing, now eyes closed.

